

Name: _____

Class: _____

Date: _____

Book Worksheet 2

Counting in the Ancient World



Read: Ancient Civilizations · The Abacus Around the World

The History of the Computer · Rachel Ignatofsky · Pages _____ to _____



The Big Picture

Long before electricity, people invented tools to count, record, and calculate. These tools store and process numbers — the same jobs computers do today.

Part 1 · Counting Tools Around the World

Fill in the table as you read.

Who / What	Who used it / where?	How did it work?
Notched bones		
Counting board		
Suanpan		
Soroban		
Quipu		
Antikythera mechanism		

Part 2 · Fill It In

Use each word from the word bank once.

abacus

Antikythera

10

quipu

suanpan

notches

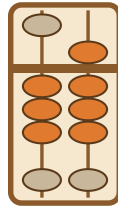
1. Early people kept count by carving _____ (tally marks) into bones and sticks.
2. An _____ uses beads on rods to add and subtract quickly.
3. The Chinese abacus is the _____; the Japanese abacus is the soroban.
4. The Inca recorded numbers using knotted strings called _____.
5. The _____ mechanism, found in a Greek shipwreck, used gears to predict the sky.
6. Our number system has _____ digits, probably because we have ten fingers.

Book Worksheet 2

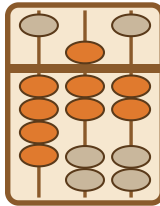
Check Your Understanding

Part 3 · Try It · Read the Soroban

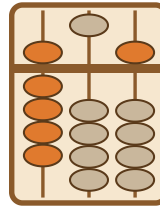
On a soroban, a bead counts when it is pushed **to the beam** (orange). The top bead is worth **5**, each bottom bead is worth **1**. Each rod is one place value — just like bits!



a. _____



b. _____



c. _____



d. Draw 216

Part 4 · Check Your Understanding

1. Why did ancient people invent counting tools?

- A. To keep track of things like trade, food, and time more accurately than memory alone
- B. To send messages over long distances
- C. To play music
- D. To decorate their homes

2. How is an abacus most like a modern computer?

- A. It uses electricity to run
- B. It can run a program by itself
- C. Each rod is a place value, and moving beads stores and processes numbers
- D. It connects to other abacuses in a network

3. On a soroban rod, the top bead and 3 bottom beads are pushed to the beam. What digit is shown?

- A. 3
- B. 4
- C. 53
- D. 8

Part 5 · Stories from History

Pick one story or person from this section that surprised you. **Who** was involved, **what** happened, and **why** does it still matter?

Part 6 · Unit 5.3 Connection

Counting tools were invented by many different civilizations. Why does it matter that a history of computing includes people from many cultures? Connect your answer to **computing bias** or to whose ideas get remembered.
